

# JAPAN ON A BUDGET

## 7 nights Japan for this summer Backpacker Guide

• Solo travel • Small budget • Big memories



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## CHAPTER 0

# Who Am I & Why This Guide ?

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Hi there! I'm Jenne, a marketing cat wandering across the cities of France, exploring data, growth, and meaningful products. 🐱

I've always been drawn to the kind of problems worth solving — those everyday frustrations that quietly affect people's lives. I'm fascinated by data, product thinking, and the challenge of building things that actually matter. Japan had been on my mind since I was a little girl watching Studio Ghibli films. I love the freedom of a nomadic lifestyle, meeting new people, discovering different perspectives, learning from every place I visit. That curiosity is what drives everything I do, whether I'm on the road or deep in a product brief.

### So why did I make this ebook and give it away for free?

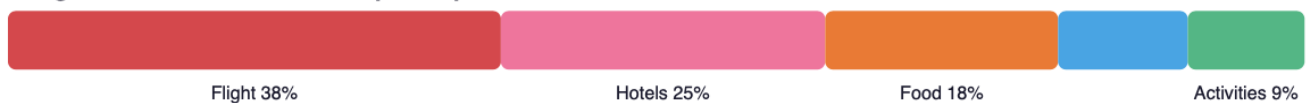
Honestly? It started as a personal experiment. I wanted to understand the people who, like me, dream big on a small budget. Who they are, what they search for, what stops them from going. This ebook is my way of connecting with them — and gathering real insight into what meaningful, accessible travel looks like in practice.

This guide is my way of paying it forward: all the research, all the budget hacks, all the things I wish someone had told me — in one place, for backpackers like me.

Enjoy and bon voyage!

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### Budget Breakdown — 1 Week Japan Trip



### ■ Budget Overview

This guide covers 7 nights in Japan for approx. 1,200-1,500€ all-in from France. Prices are indicative for 2024-2025.

## CHAPTER 1

# What's In My Bag?

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### ■ Absolute Must-Haves

| ITEM                   | WHY IT MATTERS         | TIP                        |
|------------------------|------------------------|----------------------------|
| Passport + copies      | ID required everywhere | Keep photo on phone        |
| Travel insurance card  | Medical emergencies    | Check EHIC limits          |
| IC Card (Suica/Pasmo)  | All public transport   | Load in advance at airport |
| Portable Wifi / SIM    | Maps, translate, pay   | Buy before flying          |
| Power bank (20,000mAh) | Long days out          | Charge every night         |
| Cash in 'Yen'          | Many places cash only  | ATM at 7-Eleven            |
| Universal adapter      | Japan uses Type A      | EU plug won't fit !        |
| Reusable bag (tote)    | No plastic bags in JP  | Convenience stores         |
| Small hand towel       | No paper towels        | Eco-friendly culture       |
| Basic meds kit         | Language barrier       | Paracetamol, plasters      |
| Comfortable trainers   | 10,000 + steps/day     | Sightseeing is walking     |

### ➔ Luggage Allowance Reminder

Japan airlines (ANA, JAL) allow 23kg checked + 10kg cabin. Budget carriers (Jetstar, Peach) are strict — check limits before packing!

CHAPTER 2

# Where To Go? 7-Night Itinerary

## ■ Recommended 7-Night Route

| NIGHT | CITY   | HIGHLIGHTS                             | TRAVEL                    |
|-------|--------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| 1-2   | Tokyo  | Shinjuku, Harajuku, Akihabara, TeamLab | Arrive Narita/Haneda      |
| 3     | Hakone | Mt Fuji views, Onsen, Ryokan stay      | Train from Shinjuku ~1.5h |
| 4-5   | Kyoto  | Fushimi Inari, Gion, Arashiyama bamboo | Shinkansen ~2.5h          |
| 6     | Nara   | Deer park, Todaiji Temple              | Day trip from Kyoto 45min |
| 7     | Osaka  | Dotonbori, Takoyaki, street food night | Train from Kyoto 15min    |

## ■ Ghibli & Animation Spots

| SPOT                    | CITY          | LINK / INFO                                         | EST. COST              |
|-------------------------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| Ghibli Museum           | Mitaka, Tokyo | ghibli-museum.jp — Book 1 month ahead!              | ¥1,000 (~6€)           |
| Jinbocho Book District  | Tokyo         | Anime & manga paradise — just explore!              | Free / shopping        |
| Fushimi Inari at dawn   | Kyoto         | Thousands of torii gates — feels like Spirited Away | Free                   |
| Arashiyama Bamboo Grove | Kyoto         | Princess Mononoke vibes — go at 6am                 | Free                   |
| Nausicaa Meadow (Nara)  | Nara          | Deer roam freely — pure Ghibli magic                | Free entry (deer park) |
| teamLab Borderless      | Tokyo/Osaka   | teamlab.art — interactive digital art               | ¥3,200 (~20€)          |

## ■ Traditional Experiences — Must-Do

| EXPERIENCE              | WHERE             | PRICE                          | BOOK AHEAD?           |
|-------------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Onsen (hot spring bath) | Hakone / Kinosaki | ¥600-1,500                     | No — walk-in          |
| Ryokan stay (1 night)   | Hakone            | ¥8,000-15,000<br>(with dinner) | Yes — weeks before    |
| Matcha tea ceremony     | Kyoto (Uji area)  | ¥1,500-3,000                   | Recommended           |
| Kimono rental + walk    | Kyoto (Gion)      | ¥3,000-5,000<br>(half day)     | Day before OK         |
| Taiko drumming class    | Tokyo / Kyoto     | ¥3,000-6,000                   | Yes — online          |
| Sumo morning practice   | Tokyo (Ryogoku)   | Free 'some<br>stables open'    | Check schedule online |

## ■ Events & Festivals (Summer Edition)

| EVENT                        | PERIOD      | LOCATION              | PRICE         |
|------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------|---------------|
| Hanabi (Fireworks) festivals | July-August | Tokyo, Osaka, Kyoto   | Free (public) |
| Gion Matsuri Festival        | July 1-31   | Kyoto — Gion district | Free to watch |
| Comiket (Anime convention)   | August      | Tokyo Big Sight       | ¥2,000 entry  |
| Obon Festival (lanterns)     | Mid-August  | Nationwide            | Free          |
| Tanabata (star festival)     | July 7      | Sendai / nationwide   | Free          |
| Summer Sonic music fest      | August      | Tokyo & Osaka         | ¥15,000+      |

## ■ Budget Restaurant Recommendations

| PLACE                  | CITY              | SPECIALTY                         | AVG PRICE     |
|------------------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------|
| Ichiran Ramen          | Tokyo/Osaka/Kyoto | Solo ramen booths — iconic        | ¥1,000        |
| Yoshinoya / Sukiya     | Nationwide        | Gyudon (beef bowl) — fast & cheap | ¥400-600      |
| Kura Sushi (conveyor)  | Nationwide        | 100¥ sushi plates                 | ¥800-1,500    |
| Nakamura-ya (Shinjuku) | Tokyo             | Indian-Japanese fusion bakery     | ¥500          |
| Nishiki Market stalls  | Kyoto             | Street food — try all!            | ¥200-500/item |

|                           |            |                               |          |
|---------------------------|------------|-------------------------------|----------|
| Dotonbori street food     | Osaka      | Takoyaki, okonomiyaki, crepes | ¥300-700 |
| 7-Eleven / Lawson konbini | Everywhere | Onigiri, hot food, sandwiches | ¥150-400 |

### CHAPTER 3

# Budget Hotel Options

## ■ Accommodation Type Comparison

| TYPE                  | AVG PRICE/NIGHT            | PRIVACY   | SOCIAL | BEST FOR         |
|-----------------------|----------------------------|-----------|--------|------------------|
| Capsule Hotel         | ¥2,500-4,500<br>(~15-27€)  | Low       | Med    | Solo, budget max |
| Hostel (dorm)         | ¥2,000-3,500<br>(~12-21€)  | Low       | High   | Meeting people   |
| Hostel (private)      | ¥4,000-7,000<br>(~24-42€)  | High      | Med    | Comfort + budget |
| Airbnb (shared)       | ¥3,500-6,000<br>(~21-36€)  | Med       | Low    | Local experience |
| Budget business hotel | ¥6,000-10,000<br>(~36-60€) | Very High | Low    | Comfort priority |

## ■ Capsule Hotels — Top Picks

| NAME                    | CITY        | PRICE/NIGHT | NOTES                             |
|-------------------------|-------------|-------------|-----------------------------------|
| 9 Hours Shinjuku        | Tokyo       | ¥3,200      | ■ 4.4 — Very clean, women's floor |
| Book and Bed Tokyo      | Tokyo/Kyoto | ¥4,000      | ■ 4.5 — Sleep in a bookshelf!     |
| First Cabin Kyoto       | Kyoto       | ¥4,500      | ■ 4.3 — Business class capsule    |
| Capsule Ryokan Kyoto    | Kyoto       | ¥3,800      | ■ 4.2 — Traditional aesthetic     |
| The Millennials Shibuya | Tokyo       | ¥4,200      | ■ 4.6 — Smart pod, great location |

## ■ Hostels — Top Picks

| NAME                  | CITY  | PRICE/NIGHT    | NOTES                     |
|-----------------------|-------|----------------|---------------------------|
| Khaosan World Asakusa | Tokyo | ¥2,500 dorm    | ■ 4.3 — Great social vibe |
| Guest House Waraku-an | Kyoto | ¥2,800 dorm    | ■ 4.5 — Traditional house |
| Namba Hostel & Bar    | Osaka | ¥2,200 dorm    | ■ 4.2 — Party atmosphere  |
| Imano Tokyo Ginza     | Tokyo | ¥5,500 private | ■ 4.6 — Modern & clean    |
| Piece Hostel Kyoto    | Kyoto | ¥3,000 dorm    | ■ 4.4 — Central location  |

### ■ Booking Tip — Book Early for Summer!

Book accommodation 2-3 months in advance for summer (July-August). Japan is peak season — popular places sell out fast! Use Booking.com or Hostelworld.

## CHAPTER 4

# Tips to Travel Alone in Japan

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## ■ Cultural Etiquette

| SITUATION           | DO ■                             | DON'T ■                       |
|---------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Restaurant          | Say 'Itadakimasu' before eating  | Don't tip — it's rude!        |
| Train / Metro       | Queue in line marked on platform | Don't talk on phone           |
| Onsen / Public bath | Wash body fully before entering  | Tattoos = often banned        |
| Temple / Shrine     | Bow slightly at torii gate       | Don't touch sacred objects    |
| Store / Convenience | Say 'Arigatou gozaimasu'         | Don't eat while walking       |
| Taxi / Cab          | Back door opens automatically!   | Don't touch the door          |
| Hotel               | Remove shoes at entrance         | Don't wear shoes indoors      |
| General             | Speak quietly in public          | Don't litter — zero tolerance |



## ■ Communication & SIM Cards

| OPTION               | PRICE (7 days) | DATA       | BEST FOR                 |
|----------------------|----------------|------------|--------------------------|
| IJmio Data SIM       | ~¥2,000        | 15GB       | Data only — use WhatsApp |
| Docomo Tourist SIM   | ~¥3,000        | Unlimited* | All-round best           |
| Softbank Travel SIM  | ~¥2,500        | 10GB       | Good coverage            |
| Airalo eSIM (online) | ~€10-15        | 10GB       | Buy before flying!       |
| Pocket WiFi rental   | ~¥400/day      | Unlimited  | Share with friends       |

## ■ Safety & Insurance

**Travel insurance:** Mandatory! Medical costs in Japan can be very high. AXA, MAIF (French), WorldNomads all cover Japan trips.

**Emergency number:** 110 = Police • 119 = Ambulance/Fire • Available in English

**Embassy contact (France):** +81-3-5798-6000 • embassy-france.jp

**Japan is very safe:** Violent crime is extremely rare. Solo women travel safely here. Common issues: lost items, getting lost, language barrier.

**Lost wallet?:** Items might be handed in to police koban (boxes).- check

## ■ Lost Your Passport — Step by Step

| STEP | ACTION                           | WHERE                        |
|------|----------------------------------|------------------------------|
| 1    | Report to police immediately     | Nearest koban (police box)   |
| 2    | Get the police report copy       | Keep it — you'll need it     |
| 3    | Contact French Embassy Tokyo     | +81-3-5798-6000              |
| 4    | Provide passport photo + ID copy | Always keep copies in email! |
| 5    | Emergency travel document issued | Takes 1-3 business days      |
| 6    | Contact your insurance           | They may cover extra costs   |

## ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

# Budget Calculator & Useful Links

### ■ Estimated Budget — 7 Nights from France

| CATEGORY                       | LOW BUDGET     | MID BUDGET     | NOTES                         |
|--------------------------------|----------------|----------------|-------------------------------|
| ✈ Return flights (Paris-Tokyo) | 500€           | 750€           | Book 3+ months ahead          |
| ■ Accommodation (7 nights)     | 120€           | 250€           | Capsule/hostel vs hotel       |
| ■ Food (7 days)                | 150€           | 250€           | Konbini + local restaurants   |
| ■ Transport in Japan           | 120€           | 180€           | IC Card + some trains         |
| ■ Activities & entrance fees   | 80€            | 150€           | Ghibli museum, temples...     |
| ■ SIM card / WiFi              | 15€            | 30€            | eSIM recommended              |
| ■ Shopping & souvenirs         | 100€           | 300€           | Daiso, Don Quijote, Mandarake |
| ■ Travel insurance             | 40€            | 60€            | Non-negotiable!               |
| <b>TOTAL</b>                   | <b>~1,125€</b> | <b>~1,970€</b> |                               |

### ■ Essential Apps & Websites

| APP / SITE             | USE                           | LINK                                                                                    |
|------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google Maps            | Navigation (works in Japan)   | <a href="https://maps.google.com">maps.google.com</a>                                   |
| Hyperdia / Jorudan     | Train route planner           | <a href="https://hyperdia.com">hyperdia.com</a>                                         |
| Google Translate       | Real-time camera translation  | <a href="#">App Store / Play Store</a>                                                  |
| Tabelog                | Restaurant reviews (Japanese) | <a href="https://tabelog.com">tabelog.com</a>                                           |
| Airbnb                 | Local stays                   | <a href="https://airbnb.com">airbnb.com</a>                                             |
| Hostelworld            | Hostel bookings               | <a href="https://hostelworld.com">hostelworld.com</a>                                   |
| Japan Official Tourism | All things Japan              | <a href="https://japan.travel/en">japan.travel/en</a>                                   |
| Ghibli Museum booking  | Tickets — buy early!          | <a href="https://ghibli-museum.jp">ghibli-museum.jp</a>                                 |
| Wise / Revolut         | Currency exchange (no fees)   | <a href="https://wise.com">wise.com</a> / <a href="https://revolut.com">revolut.com</a> |
| Weather Japan (JMA)    | Official forecast             | <a href="https://jma.go.jp/en">jma.go.jp/en</a>                                         |

## Final Words

Japan, Yes, it's expensive if you don't plan well. But with the right preparation, it is 100% doable on a small budget, even working at a grocery store like me ! The people are kind, the food is incredible, and the culture will blow your mind. Don't let the distance or the budget scare you.

Keep in touch with me on Tiktok : @smarterfr



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Go for it. ■■■■■■ (Ittekimasu) — I'm off! ■ © 2026 Emily •

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